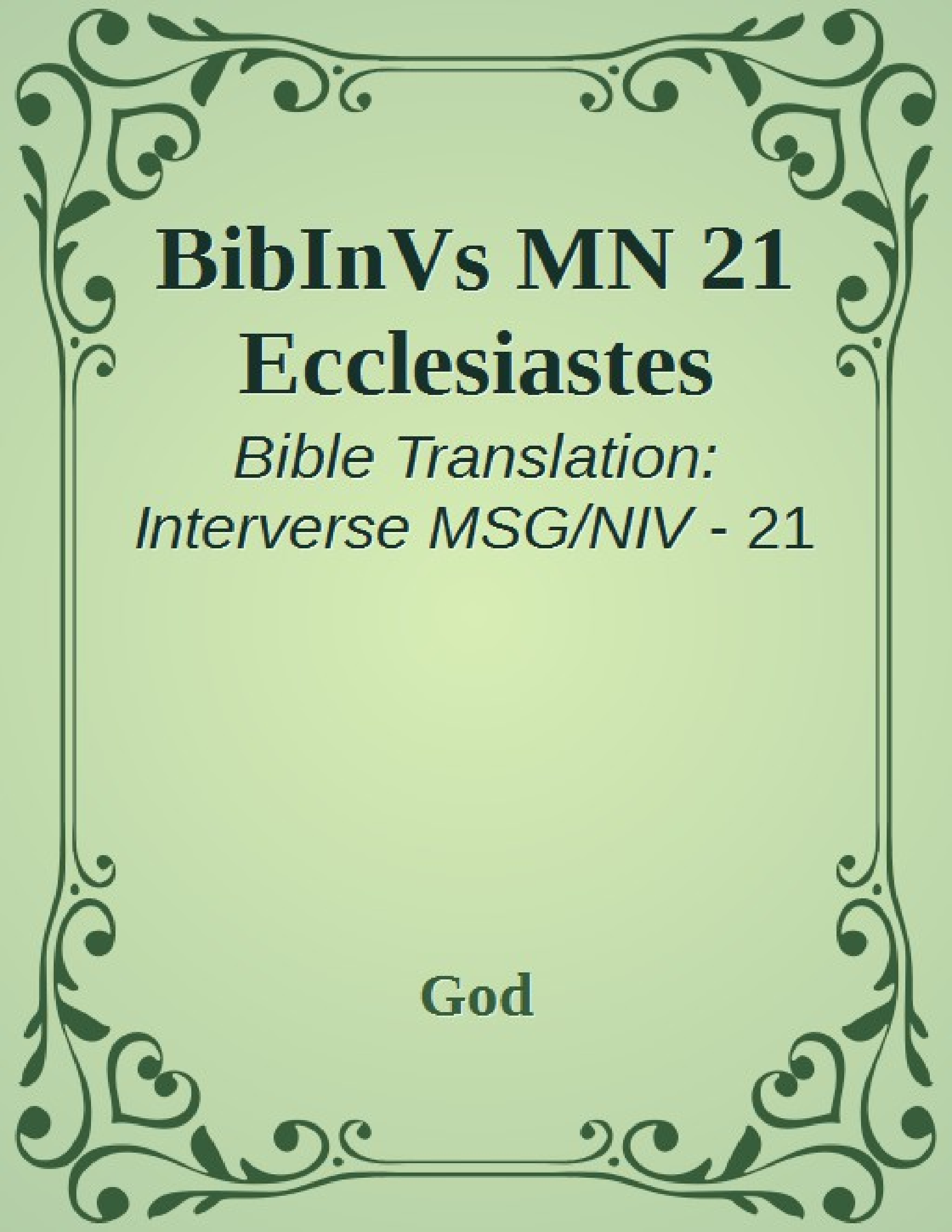


A decorative border with intricate floral and scrollwork patterns in a dark green color, framing the central text.

BibInVs MN 21

Ecclesiastes

*Bible Translation:
Interverse MSG/NIV - 21*

God

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Interversed Message/NIV Bible

Ecclesiastes

Ecclesiastes 1

MSG

NIV

- 1 These are the words of the Quester, David's son and king in Jerusalem:
- 1 The words of the Teacher, son of David, king in Jerusalem:
- 2 Smoke, nothing but smoke. [That's what the Quester says.] There's nothing to anything--it's all smoke.
- 2 Meaningless! Meaningless! says the Teacher. "Utterly meaningless! Everything is meaningless."
- 3 What's there to show for a lifetime of work, a lifetime of working your fingers to the bone?
- 3 What does man gain from all his labor at which he toils under the sun?
- 4 One generation goes its way, the next one arrives, but nothing changes--it's business as usual for old planet earth.
- 4 Generations come and generations go, but the earth remains forever.
- 5 The sun comes up and the sun goes down, then does it again, and again--the same old round.
- 5 The sun rises and the sun sets, and hurries back to where it rises.
- 6 The wind blows south, the wind blows north. Around and around and around it blows, blowing this way, then that--the whirling, erratic wind.
- 6 The wind blows to the south and turns to the north; round and round it goes, ever returning on its course.
- 7 All the rivers flow into the sea, but the sea never fills up. The rivers keep flowing to the same old place, and then start all over and do it again.
- 7 All streams flow into the sea, yet the sea is never full. To the place the streams come from, there they return again.
- 8 Everything's boring, utterly boring-- no one can find any meaning in it. Boring to the eye, boring to the ear.
- 8 All things are wearisome, more than one can say. The eye never has enough of seeing, nor the ear its fill of hearing.

- 9 What was will be again, what happened will happen again. There's nothing new on this earth. Year after year it's the same old thing.
- 9 What has been will be again, what has been done will be done again; there is nothing new under the sun.
- 10 Does someone call out, "Hey, this is new"? Don't get excited--it's the same old story.
- 10 Is there anything of which one can say, "Look! This is something new"? It was here already, long ago; it was here before our time.
- 11 Nobody remembers what happened yesterday. And the things that will happen tomorrow? Nobody'll remember them either. Don't count on being remembered.
- 11 There is no remembrance of men of old, and even those who are yet to come will not be remembered by those who follow.
- 12 Call me "the Quester." I've been king over Israel in Jerusalem.
- 12 I, the Teacher, was king over Israel in Jerusalem.
- 13 I looked most carefully into everything, searched out all that is done on this earth. And let me tell you, there's not much to write home about. God hasn't made it easy for us.
- 13 I devoted myself to study and to explore by wisdom all that is done under heaven. What a heavy burden God has laid on men!
- 14 I've seen it all and it's nothing but smoke--smoke, and spitting into the wind.
- 14 I have seen all the things that are done under the sun; all of them are meaningless, a chasing after the wind.
- 15 Life's a corkscrew that can't be straightened, A minus that won't add up.
- 15 What is twisted cannot be straightened; what is lacking cannot be counted.
- 16 I said to myself, "I know more and I'm wiser than anyone before me in Jerusalem. I've stockpiled wisdom and knowledge."
- 16 I thought to myself, "Look, I have grown and increased in wisdom more than anyone who has ruled over Jerusalem before me; I have experienced much of wisdom and knowledge."
- 17 What I've finally concluded is that so-called wisdom and knowledge are mindless and witless--nothing but spitting into the wind.
- 17 Then I applied myself to the understanding of wisdom, and also of madness and folly, but I learned that this, too, is a chasing after the wind.

18 Much learning earns you much trouble. The more you know, the more you hurt.

18 For with much wisdom comes much sorrow; the more knowledge, the more grief.

Ecclesiastes 2

MSG

NIV

1 I said to myself, "Let's go for it--experiment with pleasure, have a good time!" But there was nothing to it, nothing but smoke.

1 I thought in my heart, "Come now, I will test you with pleasure to find out what is good." But that also proved to be meaningless.

2 What do I think of the fun-filled life? Insane! Inane! My verdict on the pursuit of happiness? Who needs it?

2 Laughter, I said, "is foolish. And what does pleasure accomplish?"

3 With the help of a bottle of wine and all the wisdom I could muster, I tried my level best to penetrate the absurdity of life. I wanted to get a handle on anything useful we mortals might do during the years we spend on this earth.

3 I tried cheering myself with wine, and embracing folly--my mind still guiding me with wisdom. I wanted to see what was worthwhile for men to do under heaven during the few days of their lives.

4 Oh, I did great things: built houses, planted vineyards,

4 I undertook great projects: I built houses for myself and planted vineyards.

5 designed gardens and parks and planted a variety of fruit trees in them,

5 I made gardens and parks and planted all kinds of fruit trees in them.

6 made pools of water to irrigate the groves of trees.

6 I made reservoirs to water groves of flourishing trees.

7 I bought slaves, male and female, who had children, giving me even more slaves; then I acquired large herds and flocks, larger than any before me in Jerusalem.

7 I bought male and female slaves and had other slaves who were born in my house. I also owned more herds and flocks than anyone in Jerusalem before me.

- 8 I piled up silver and gold, loot from kings and kingdoms. I gathered a chorus of singers to entertain me with song, and--most exquisite of all pleasures-- voluptuous maidens for my bed.
- 8 I amassed silver and gold for myself, and the treasure of kings and provinces. I acquired men and women singers, and a harem as well--the delights of the heart of man.
- 9 Oh, how I prospered! I left all my predecessors in Jerusalem far behind, left them behind in the dust. What's more, I kept a clear head through it all.
- 9 I became greater by far than anyone in Jerusalem before me. In all this my wisdom stayed with me.
- 10 Everything I wanted I took--I never said no to myself. I gave in to every impulse, held back nothing. I sucked the marrow of pleasure out of every task--my reward to myself for a hard day's work!
- 10 I denied myself nothing my eyes desired; I refused my heart no pleasure. My heart took delight in all my work, and this was the reward for all my labor.
- 11 Then I took a good look at everything I'd done, looked at all the sweat and hard work. But when I looked, I saw nothing but smoke. Smoke and spitting into the wind. There was nothing to any of it. Nothing.
- 11 Yet when I surveyed all that my hands had done and what I had toiled to achieve, everything was meaningless, a chasing after the wind; nothing was gained under the sun.
- 12 And then I took a hard look at what's smart and what's stupid. What's left to do after you've been king? That's a hard act to follow. You just do what you can, and that's it.
- 12 Then I turned my thoughts to consider wisdom, and also madness and folly. What more can the king's successor do than what has already been done?
- 13 But I did see that it's better to be smart than stupid, just as light is better than darkness.
- 13 I saw that wisdom is better than folly, just as light is better than darkness.
- 14 Even so, though the smart ones see where they're going and the stupid ones grope in the dark, they're all the same in the end. One fate for all--and that's it.

- 14 The wise man has eyes in his head, while the fool walks in the darkness; but I came to realize that the same fate overtakes them both.
- 15 When I realized that my fate's the same as the fool's, I had to ask myself, "So why bother being wise?" It's all smoke, nothing but smoke.
- 15 Then I thought in my heart, "The fate of the fool will overtake me also. What then do I gain by being wise?" I said in my heart, "This too is meaningless."
- 16 The smart and the stupid both disappear out of sight. In a day or two they're both forgotten. Yes, both the smart and the stupid die, and that's it.
- 16 For the wise man, like the fool, will not be long remembered; in days to come both will be forgotten. Like the fool, the wise man too must die!
- 17 I hate life. As far as I can see, what happens on earth is a bad business. It's smoke--and spitting into the wind.
- 17 So I hated life, because the work that is done under the sun was grievous to me. All of it is meaningless, a chasing after the wind.
- 18 And I hated everything I'd accomplished and accumulated on this earth. I can't take it with me--no, I have to leave it to whoever comes after me.
- 18 I hated all the things I had toiled for under the sun, because I must leave them to the one who comes after me.
- 19 Whether they're worthy or worthless--and who's to tell?--they'll take over the earthly results of my intense thinking and hard work. Smoke.
- 19 And who knows whether he will be a wise man or a fool? Yet he will have control over all the work into which I have poured my effort and skill under the sun. This too is meaningless.
- 20 That's when I called it quits, gave up on anything that could be hoped for on this earth.
- 20 So my heart began to despair over all my toilsome labor under the sun.
- 21 What's the point of working your fingers to the bone if you hand over what you worked for to someone who never lifted a finger for it? Smoke, that's what it is. A bad business from start to finish.
- 21 For a man may do his work with wisdom, knowledge and skill, and then he must leave all he owns to someone who has not worked for it. This too is meaningless and a great misfortune.
- 22 So what do you get from a life of hard labor?

- 22 What does a man get for all the toil and anxious striving with which he labors under the sun?
- 23 Pain and grief from dawn to dusk. Never a decent night's rest. Nothing but smoke.
- 23 All his days his work is pain and grief; even at night his mind does not rest. This too is meaningless.
- 24 The best you can do with your life is have a good time and get by the best you can. The way I see it, that's it--divine fate.
- 24 A man can do nothing better than to eat and drink and find satisfaction in his work. This too, I see, is from the hand of God,
- 25 Whether we feast or fast, it's up to God.
- 25 for without him, who can eat or find enjoyment?
- 26 God may give wisdom and knowledge and joy to his favorites, but sinners are assigned a life of hard labor, and end up turning their wages over to God's favorites. Nothing but smoke--and spitting into the wind.
- 26 To the man who pleases him, God gives wisdom, knowledge and happiness, but to the sinner he gives the task of gathering and storing up wealth to hand it over to the one who pleases God. This too is meaningless, a chasing after the wind.

Ecclesiastes 3

MSG

NIV

- 1 There's an opportune time to do things, a right time for everything on the earth:
- 1 There is a time for everything, and a season for every activity under heaven:
- 2 A right time for birth and another for death, A right time to plant and another to reap,
- 2 a time to be born and a time to die, a time to plant and a time to uproot,
- 3 A right time to kill and another to heal, A right time to destroy and another to construct,
- 3 a time to kill and a time to heal, a time to tear down and a time to build,
- 4 A right time to cry and another to laugh, A right time to lament and another to cheer,

4 a time to weep and a time to laugh, a time to mourn and a time to dance,
5 A right time to make love and another to abstain, A right time to embrace
and another to part,
5 a time to scatter stones and a time to gather them, a time to embrace and
a time to refrain,
6 A right time to search and another to count your losses, A right time to
hold on and another to let go,
6 a time to search and a time to give up, a time to keep and a time to throw
away,
7 A right time to rip out and another to mend, A right time to shut up and
another to speak up,
7 a time to tear and a time to mend, a time to be silent and a time to speak,
8 A right time to love and another to hate, A right time to wage war and
another to make peace.
8 a time to love and a time to hate, a time for war and a time for peace.
9 But in the end, does it really make a difference what anyone does?
9 What does the worker gain from his toil?
10 I've had a good look at what God has given us to do--busywork, mostly.
10 I have seen the burden God has laid on men.
11 True, God made everything beautiful in itself and in its time--but he's
left us in the dark, so we can never know what God is up to, whether he's
coming or going.
11 He has made everything beautiful in its time. He has also set eternity in
the hearts of men; yet they cannot fathom what God has done from
beginning to end.
12 I've decided that there's nothing better to do than go ahead and have a
good time and get the most we can out of life.
12 I know that there is nothing better for men than to be happy and do good
while they live.
13 That's it--eat, drink, and make the most of your job. It's God's gift.
13 That everyone may eat and drink, and find satisfaction in all his toil--
this is the gift of God.
14 I've also concluded that whatever God does, that's the way it's going to
be, always. No addition, no subtraction. God's done it and that's it. That's
so we'll quit asking questions and simply worship in holy fear.

- 14 I know that everything God does will endure forever; nothing can be added to it and nothing taken from it. God does it so that men will revere him.
- 15 Whatever was, is. Whatever will be, is. That's how it always is with God.
- 15 Whatever is has already been, and what will be has been before; and God will call the past to account.
- 16 I took another good look at what's going on: The very place of judgment--corrupt!
- 16 And I saw something else under the sun: In the place of judgment--wickedness was there, in the place of justice--wickedness was there.
- 17 The place of righteousness--corrupt! I said to myself, "God will judge righteous and wicked." There's a right time for every thing, every deed--and there's no getting around it.
- 17 I thought in my heart, "God will bring to judgment both the righteous and the wicked, for there will be a time for every activity, a time for every deed."
- 18 I said to myself regarding the human race, "God's testing the lot of us, showing us up as nothing but animals."
- 18 I also thought, "As for men, God tests them so that they may see that they are like the animals.
- 19 Humans and animals come to the same end--humans die, animals die. We all breathe the same air. So there's really no advantage in being human. None. Everything's smoke.
- 19 Man's fate is like that of the animals; the same fate awaits them both: As one dies, so dies the other. All have the same breath; man has no advantage over the animal. Everything is meaningless.
- 20 We all end up in the same place--we all came from dust, we all end up as dust.
- 20 All go to the same place; all come from dust, and to dust all return.
- 21 Nobody knows for sure that the human spirit rises to heaven or that the animal spirit sinks into the earth.
- 21 Who knows if the spirit of man rises upward and if the spirit of the animal goes down into the earth?"
- 22 So I made up my mind that there's nothing better for us men and women than to have a good time in whatever we do--that's our lot. Who knows if

there's anything else to life?

- 22 So I saw that there is nothing better for a man than to enjoy his work, because that is his lot. For who can bring him to see what will happen after him?

Ecclesiastes 4

MSG

NIV

- 1 Next I turned my attention to all the outrageous violence that takes place on this planet--the tears of the victims, no one to comfort them; the iron grip of oppressors, no one to rescue the victims from them.
- 1 Again I looked and saw all the oppression that was taking place under the sun: I saw the tears of the oppressed-- and they have no comforter; power was on the side of their oppressors-- and they have no comforter.
- 2 So I congratulated the dead who are already dead instead of the living who are still alive.
- 2 And I declared that the dead, who had already died, are happier than the living, who are still alive.
- 3 But luckier than the dead or the living is the person who has never even been, who has never seen the bad business that takes place on this earth.
- 3 But better than both is he who has not yet been, who has not seen the evil that is done under the sun.
- 4 Then I observed all the work and ambition motivated by envy. What a waste! Smoke. And spitting into the wind.
- 4 And I saw that all labor and all achievement spring from man's envy of his neighbor. This too is meaningless, a chasing after the wind.
- 5 The fool sits back and takes it easy, His sloth is slow suicide.
- 5 The fool folds his hands and ruins himself.
- 6 One handful of peaceful repose Is better than two fistfuls of worried work-- More spitting into the wind.
- 6 Better one handful with tranquillity than two handfuls with toil and chasing after the wind.
- 7 I turned my head and saw yet another wisp of smoke on its way to nothingness:
- 7 Again I saw something meaningless under the sun:

- 8 a solitary person, completely alone--no children, no family, no friends--yet working obsessively late into the night, compulsively greedy for more and more, never bothering to ask, "Why am I working like a dog, never having any fun? And who cares?" More smoke. A bad business.
- 8 There was a man all alone; he had neither son nor brother. There was no end to his toil, yet his eyes were not content with his wealth. "For whom am I toiling," he asked, "and why am I depriving myself of enjoyment?" This too is meaningless-- a miserable business!
- 9 It's better to have a partner than go it alone. Share the work, share the wealth.
- 9 Two are better than one, because they have a good return for their work:
- 10 And if one falls down, the other helps, But if there's no one to help, tough!
- 10 If one falls down, his friend can help him up. But pity the man who falls and has no one to help him up!
- 11 Two in a bed warm each other. Alone, you shiver all night.
- 11 Also, if two lie down together, they will keep warm. But how can one keep warm alone?
- 12 By yourself you're unprotected. With a friend you can face the worst. Can you round up a third? A three-stranded rope isn't easily snapped.
- 12 Though one may be overpowered, two can defend themselves. A cord of three strands is not quickly broken.
- 13 A poor youngster with some wisdom is better off than an old but foolish king who doesn't know which end is up.
- 13 Better a poor but wise youth than an old but foolish king who no longer knows how to take warning.
- 14 I saw a youth just like this start with nothing and go from rags to riches,
- 14 The youth may have come from prison to the kingship, or he may have been born in poverty within his kingdom.
- 15 and I saw everyone rally to the rule of this young successor to the king.
- 15 I saw that all who lived and walked under the sun followed the youth, the king's successor.
- 16 Even so, the excitement died quickly, the throngs of people soon lost interest. Can't you see it's only smoke? And spitting into the wind?
- 16 There was no end to all the people who were before them. But those who came later were not pleased with the successor. This too is

meaningless, a chasing after the wind.

Ecclesiastes 5

MSG

NIV

- 1 Watch your step when you enter God's house. Enter to learn. That's far better than mindlessly offering a sacrifice, Doing more harm than good.
- 1 Guard your steps when you go to the house of God. Go near to listen rather than to offer the sacrifice of fools, who do not know that they do wrong.
- 2 Don't shoot off your mouth, or speak before you think. Don't be too quick to tell God what you think he wants to hear. God's in charge, not you--the less you speak, the better.
- 2 Do not be quick with your mouth, do not be hasty in your heart to utter anything before God. God is in heaven and you are on earth, so let your words be few.
- 3 Over-work makes for restless sleep. Over-talk shows you up as a fool.
- 3 As a dream comes when there are many cares, so the speech of a fool when there are many words.
- 4 When you tell God you'll do something, do it--now. God takes no pleasure in foolish gabble. Vow it, then do it.
- 4 When you make a vow to God, do not delay in fulfilling it. He has no pleasure in fools; fulfill your vow.
- 5 Far better not to vow in the first place than to vow and not pay up.
- 5 It is better not to vow than to make a vow and not fulfill it.
- 6 Don't let your mouth make a total sinner of you. When called to account, you won't get by with "Sorry, I didn't mean it." Why risk provoking God to angry retaliation?
- 6 Do not let your mouth lead you into sin. And do not protest to the temple messenger, "My vow was a mistake." Why should God be angry at what you say and destroy the work of your hands?
- 7 But against all illusion and fantasy and empty talk There's always this rock foundation: Fear God!
- 7 Much dreaming and many words are meaningless. Therefore stand in awe of God.

- 8 Don't be too upset when you see the poor kicked around, and justice and right violated all over the place. Exploitation filters down from one petty official to another. There's no end to it, and nothing can be done about it.
- 8 If you see the poor oppressed in a district, and justice and rights denied, do not be surprised at such things; for one official is eyed by a higher one, and over them both are others higher still.
- 9 But the good earth doesn't cheat anyone--even a bad king is honestly served by a field.
- 9 The increase from the land is taken by all; the king himself profits from the fields.
- 10 The one who loves money is never satisfied with money, Nor the one who loves wealth with big profits. More smoke.
- 10 Whoever loves money never has money enough; whoever loves wealth is never satisfied with his income. This too is meaningless.
- 11 The more loot you get, the more looters show up. And what fun is that--to be robbed in broad daylight?
- 11 As goods increase, so do those who consume them. And what benefit are they to the owner except to feast his eyes on them?
- 12 Hard and honest work earns a good night's sleep, Whether supper is beans or steak. But a rich man's belly gives him insomnia.
- 12 The sleep of a laborer is sweet, whether he eats little or much, but the abundance of a rich man permits him no sleep.
- 13 Here's a piece of bad luck I've seen happen: A man hoards far more wealth than is good for him
- 13 I have seen a grievous evil under the sun: wealth hoarded to the harm of its owner,
- 14 And then loses it all in a bad business deal. He fathered a child but hasn't a cent left to give him.
- 14 or wealth lost through some misfortune, so that when he has a son there is nothing left for him.
- 15 He arrived naked from the womb of his mother; He'll leave in the same condition--with nothing.
- 15 Naked a man comes from his mother's womb, and as he comes, so he departs. He takes nothing from his labor that he can carry in his hand.
- 16 This is bad luck, for sure--naked he came, naked he went. So what was the point of working for a salary of smoke?

- 16 This too is a grievous evil: As a man comes, so he departs, and what does he gain, since he toils for the wind?
- 17 All for a miserable life spent in the dark?
- 17 All his days he eats in darkness, with great frustration, affliction and anger.
- 18 After looking at the way things are on this earth, here's what I've decided is the best way to live: Take care of yourself, have a good time, and make the most of whatever job you have for as long as God gives you life. And that's about it. That's the human lot.
- 18 Then I realized that it is good and proper for a man to eat and drink, and to find satisfaction in his toilsome labor under the sun during the few days of life God has given him--for this is his lot.
- 19 Yes, we should make the most of what God gives, both the bounty and the capacity to enjoy it, accepting what's given and delighting in the work. It's God's gift!
- 19 Moreover, when God gives any man wealth and possessions, and enables him to enjoy them, to accept his lot and be happy in his work--this is a gift of God.
- 20 God deals out joy in the present, the now. It's useless to brood over how long we might live.
- 20 He seldom reflects on the days of his life, because God keeps him occupied with gladness of heart.

Ecclesiastes 6

MSG

NIV

- 1 I looked long and hard at what goes on around here, and let me tell you, things are bad. And people feel it.
- 1 I have seen another evil under the sun, and it weighs heavily on men:
- 2 There are people, for instance, on whom God showers everything--money, property, reputation--all they ever wanted or dreamed of. And then God doesn't let them enjoy it. Some stranger comes along and has all the fun. It's more of what I'm calling smoke. A bad business.
- 2 God gives a man wealth, possessions and honor, so that he lacks nothing his heart desires, but God does not enable him to enjoy them, and a

- stranger enjoys them instead. This is meaningless, a grievous evil.
- 3 Say a couple have scores of children and live a long, long life but never enjoy themselves--even though they end up with a big funeral! I'd say that a stillborn baby gets the better deal.
- 3 A man may have a hundred children and live many years; yet no matter how long he lives, if he cannot enjoy his prosperity and does not receive proper burial, I say that a stillborn child is better off than he.
- 4 It gets its start in a mist and ends up in the dark--unnamed.
- 4 It comes without meaning, it departs in darkness, and in darkness its name is shrouded.
- 5 It sees nothing and knows nothing, but is better off by far than anyone living.
- 5 Though it never saw the sun or knew anything, it has more rest than does that man--
- 6 Even if someone lived a thousand years--make it two thousand!--but didn't enjoy anything, what's the point? Doesn't everyone end up in the same place?
- 6 even if he lives a thousand years twice over but fails to enjoy his prosperity. Do not all go to the same place?
- 7 We work to feed our appetites; Meanwhile our souls go hungry.
- 7 All man's efforts are for his mouth, yet his appetite is never satisfied.
- 8 So what advantage has a sage over a fool, or over some poor wretch who barely gets by?
- 8 What advantage has a wise man over a fool? What does a poor man gain by knowing how to conduct himself before others?
- 9 Just grab whatever you can while you can; don't assume something better might turn up by and by. All it amounts to anyway is smoke. And spitting into the wind.
- 9 Better what the eye sees than the roving of the appetite. This too is meaningless, a chasing after the wind.
- 10 Whatever happens, happens. Its destiny is fixed. You can't argue with fate.
- 10 Whatever exists has already been named, and what man is has been known; no man can contend with one who is stronger than he.
- 11 The more words that are spoken, the more smoke there is in the air. And who is any better off?

- 11 The more the words, the less the meaning, and how does that profit anyone?
- 12 And who knows what's best for us as we live out our meager smoke-and-shadow lives? And who can tell any of us the next chapter of our lives?
- 12 For who knows what is good for a man in life, during the few and meaningless days he passes through like a shadow? Who can tell him what will happen under the sun after he is gone?

Ecclesiastes 7

MSG

NIV

- 1 A good reputation is better than a fat bank account. Your death date tells more than your birth date.
- 1 A good name is better than fine perfume, and the day of death better than the day of birth.
- 2 You learn more at a funeral than at a feast-- After all, that's where we'll end up. We might discover something from it.
- 2 It is better to go to a house of mourning than to go to a house of feasting, for death is the destiny of every man; the living should take this to heart.
- 3 Crying is better than laughing. It blotches the face but it scourges the heart.
- 3 Sorrow is better than laughter, because a sad face is good for the heart.
- 4 Sages invest themselves in hurt and grieving. Fools waste their lives in fun and games.
- 4 The heart of the wise is in the house of mourning, but the heart of fools is in the house of pleasure.
- 5 You'll get more from the rebuke of a sage Than from the song and dance of fools.
- 5 It is better to heed a wise man's rebuke than to listen to the song of fools.
- 6 The giggles of fools are like the crackling of twigs Under the cooking pot. And like smoke.
- 6 Like the crackling of thorns under the pot, so is the laughter of fools. This too is meaningless.
- 7 Brutality stupefies even the wise And destroys the strongest heart.
- 7 Extortion turns a wise man into a fool, and a bribe corrupts the heart.

- 8 Endings are better than beginnings. Sticking to it is better than standing out.
- 8 The end of a matter is better than its beginning, and patience is better than pride.
- 9 Don't be quick to fly off the handle. Anger boomerangs. You can spot a fool by the lumps on his head.
- 9 Do not be quickly provoked in your spirit, for anger resides in the lap of fools.
- 10 Don't always be asking, "Where are the good old days?" Wise folks don't ask questions like that.
- 10 Do not say, "Why were the old days better than these?" For it is not wise to ask such questions.
- 11 Wisdom is better when it's paired with money, Especially if you get both while you're still living.
- 11 Wisdom, like an inheritance, is a good thing and benefits those who see the sun.
- 12 Double protection: wisdom and wealth! Plus this bonus: Wisdom energizes its owner.
- 12 Wisdom is a shelter as money is a shelter, but the advantage of knowledge is this: that wisdom preserves the life of its possessor.
- 13 Take a good look at God's work. Who could simplify and reduce Creation's curves and angles To a plain straight line?
- 13 Consider what God has done: Who can straighten what he has made crooked?
- 14 On a good day, enjoy yourself; On a bad day, examine your conscience. God arranges for both kinds of days So that we won't take anything for granted.
- 14 When times are good, be happy; but when times are bad, consider: God has made the one as well as the other. Therefore, a man cannot discover anything about his future.
- 15 I've seen it all in my brief and pointless life--here a good person cut down in the middle of doing good, there a bad person living a long life of sheer evil.
- 15 In this meaningless life of mine I have seen both of these: a righteous man perishing in his righteousness, and a wicked man living long in his wickedness.

- 16 So don't knock yourself out being good, and don't go overboard being wise. Believe me, you won't get anything out of it.
- 16 Do not be overrighteous, neither be overwise-- why destroy yourself?
- 17 But don't press your luck by being bad, either. And don't be reckless. Why die needlessly?
- 17 Do not be overwicked, and do not be a fool-- why die before your time?
- 18 It's best to stay in touch with both sides of an issue. A person who fears God deals responsibly with all of reality, not just a piece of it.
- 18 It is good to grasp the one and not let go of the other. The man who fears God will avoid all extremes.
- 19 Wisdom puts more strength in one wise person Than ten strong men give to a city.
- 19 Wisdom makes one wise man more powerful than ten rulers in a city.
- 20 There's not one totally good person on earth, Not one who is truly pure and sinless.
- 20 There is not a righteous man on earth who does what is right and never sins.
- 21 Don't eavesdrop on the conversation of others. What if the gossip's about you and you'd rather not hear it?
- 21 Do not pay attention to every word people say, or you may hear your servant cursing you--
- 22 You've done that a few times, haven't you--said things Behind someone's back you wouldn't say to his face?
- 22 for you know in your heart that many times you yourself have cursed others.
- 23 I tested everything in my search for wisdom. I set out to be wise, but it was beyond me,
- 23 All this I tested by wisdom and I said, "I am determined to be wise"-- but this was beyond me.
- 24 far beyond me, and deep--oh so deep! Does anyone ever find it?
- 24 Whatever wisdom may be, it is far off and most profound-- who can discover it?
- 25 I concentrated with all my might, studying and exploring and seeking wisdom--the meaning of life. I also wanted to identify evil and stupidity, foolishness and craziness.

- 25 So I turned my mind to understand, to investigate and to search out wisdom and the scheme of things and to understand the stupidity of wickedness and the madness of folly.
- 26 One discovery: A woman can be a bitter pill to swallow, full of seductive scheming and grasping. The lucky escape her; the undiscerning get caught.
- 26 I find more bitter than death the woman who is a snare, whose heart is a trap and whose hands are chains. The man who pleases God will escape her, but the sinner she will ensnare.
- 27 At least this is my experience--what I, the Quester, have pieced together as I've tried to make sense of life.
- 27 Look, says the Teacher, "this is what I have discovered: "Adding one thing to another to discover the scheme of things--
- 28 But the wisdom I've looked for I haven't found. I didn't find one man or woman in a thousand worth my while.
- 28 while I was still searching but not finding-- I found one upright man among a thousand, but not one upright woman among them all.
- 29 Yet I did spot one ray of light in this murk: God made men and women true and upright; we're the ones who've made a mess of things.
- 29 This only have I found: God made mankind upright, but men have gone in search of many schemes."

Ecclesiastes 8

MSG

NIV

- 1 There's nothing better than being wise, Knowing how to interpret the meaning of life. Wisdom puts light in the eyes, And gives gentleness to words and manners.
- 1 Who is like the wise man? Who knows the explanation of things? Wisdom brightens a man's face and changes its hard appearance.
- 2 Do what your king commands; you gave a sacred oath of obedience.
- 2 Obey the king's command, I say, because you took an oath before God.
- 3 Don't worryingly second-guess your orders or try to back out when the task is unpleasant. You're serving his pleasure, not yours.

- 3 Do not be in a hurry to leave the king's presence. Do not stand up for a bad cause, for he will do whatever he pleases.
- 4 The king has the last word. Who dares say to him, "What are you doing?"
- 4 Since a king's word is supreme, who can say to him, "What are you doing?"
- 5 Carrying out orders won't hurt you a bit; the wise person obeys promptly and accurately.
- 5 Whoever obeys his command will come to no harm, and the wise heart will know the proper time and procedure.
- 6 Yes, there's a right time and way for everything, even though, unfortunately, we miss it for the most part.
- 6 For there is a proper time and procedure for every matter, though a man's misery weighs heavily upon him.
- 7 It's true that no one knows what's going to happen, or when. Who's around to tell us?
- 7 Since no man knows the future, who can tell him what is to come?
- 8 No one can control the wind or lock it in a box. No one has any say-so regarding the day of death. No one can stop a battle in its tracks. No one who does evil can be saved by evil.
- 8 No man has power over the wind to contain it; so no one has power over the day of his death. As no one is discharged in time of war, so wickedness will not release those who practice it.
- 9 All this I observed as I tried my best to understand all that's going on in this world. As long as men and women have the power to hurt each other, this is the way it is.
- 9 All this I saw, as I applied my mind to everything done under the sun. There is a time when a man lords it over others to his own hurt.
- 10 One time I saw wicked men given a solemn burial in holy ground. When the people returned to the city, they delivered flowery eulogies--and in the very place where wicked acts were done by those very men! More smoke. Indeed.
- 10 Then too, I saw the wicked buried--those who used to come and go from the holy place and receive praise in the city where they did this. This too is meaningless.
- 11 Because the sentence against evil deeds is so long in coming, people in general think they can get by with murder.

- 11 When the sentence for a crime is not quickly carried out, the hearts of the people are filled with schemes to do wrong.
- 12 Even though a person sins and gets by with it hundreds of times throughout a long life, I'm still convinced that the good life is reserved for the person who fears God, who lives reverently in his presence,
- 12 Although a wicked man commits a hundred crimes and still lives a long time, I know that it will go better with God-fearing men, who are reverent before God.
- 13 and that the evil person will not experience a "good" life. No matter how many days he lives, they'll all be as flat and colorless as a shadow--because he doesn't fear God.
- 13 Yet because the wicked do not fear God, it will not go well with them, and their days will not lengthen like a shadow.
- 14 Here's something that happens all the time and makes no sense at all: Good people get what's coming to the wicked, and bad people get what's coming to the good. I tell you, this makes no sense. It's smoke.
- 14 There is something else meaningless that occurs on earth: righteous men who get what the wicked deserve, and wicked men who get what the righteous deserve. This too, I say, is meaningless.
- 15 So, I'm all for just going ahead and having a good time--the best possible. The only earthly good men and women can look forward to is to eat and drink well and have a good time--compensation for the struggle for survival these few years God gives us on earth.
- 15 So I commend the enjoyment of life, because nothing is better for a man under the sun than to eat and drink and be glad. Then joy will accompany him in his work all the days of the life God has given him under the sun.
- 16 When I determined to load up on wisdom and examine everything taking place on earth, I realized that if you keep your eyes open day and night without even blinking,
- 16 When I applied my mind to know wisdom and to observe man's labor on earth--his eyes not seeing sleep day or night--
- 17 you'll still never figure out the meaning of what God is doing on this earth. Search as hard as you like, you're not going to make sense of it. No matter how smart you are, you won't get to the bottom of it.

17 then I saw all that God has done. No one can comprehend what goes on under the sun. Despite all his efforts to search it out, man cannot discover its meaning. Even if a wise man claims he knows, he cannot really comprehend it.

Ecclesiastes 9

MSG

NIV

- 1 Well, I took all this in and thought it through, inside and out. Here's what I understood: The good, the wise, and all that they do are in God's hands--but, day by day, whether it's love or hate they're dealing with, they don't know. Anything's possible.
- 1 So I reflected on all this and concluded that the righteous and the wise and what they do are in God's hands, but no man knows whether love or hate awaits him.
- 2 It's one fate for everybody--righteous and wicked, good people, bad people, the nice and the nasty, worshipers and non-worshipers, committed and uncommitted.
- 2 All share a common destiny--the righteous and the wicked, the good and the bad, the clean and the unclean, those who offer sacrifices and those who do not. As it is with the good man, so with the sinner; as it is with those who take oaths, so with those who are afraid to take them.
- 3 I find this outrageous--the worst thing about living on this earth--that everyone's lumped together in one fate. Is it any wonder that so many people are obsessed with evil? Is it any wonder that people go crazy right and left? Life leads to death. That's it.
- 3 This is the evil in everything that happens under the sun: The same destiny overtakes all. The hearts of men, moreover, are full of evil and there is madness in their hearts while they live, and afterward they join the dead.
- 4 Still, anyone selected out for life has hope, for, as they say, "A living dog is better than a dead lion."
- 4 Anyone who is among the living has hope--even a live dog is better off than a dead lion!

- 5 The living at least know something, even if it's only that they're going to die. But the dead know nothing and get nothing. They're a minus that no one remembers.
- 5 For the living know that they will die, but the dead know nothing; they have no further reward, and even the memory of them is forgotten.
- 6 Their loves, their hates, yes, even their dreams, are long gone. There's not a trace of them left in the affairs of this earth.
- 6 Their love, their hate and their jealousy have long since vanished; never again will they have a part in anything that happens under the sun.
- 7 Seize life! Eat bread with gusto, Drink wine with a robust heart. Oh yes-- God takes pleasure in your pleasure!
- 7 Go, eat your food with gladness, and drink your wine with a joyful heart, for it is now that God favors what you do.
- 8 Dress festively every morning. Don't skimp on colors and scarves.
- 8 Always be clothed in white, and always anoint your head with oil.
- 9 Relish life with the spouse you love Each and every day of your precarious life. Each day is God's gift. It's all you get in exchange For the hard work of staying alive. Make the most of each one!
- 9 Enjoy life with your wife, whom you love, all the days of this meaningless life that God has given you under the sun-- all your meaningless days. For this is your lot in life and in your toilsome labor under the sun.
- 10 Whatever turns up, grab it and do it. And heartily! This is your last and only chance at it, For there's neither work to do nor thoughts to think In the company of the dead, where you're most certainly headed.
- 10 Whatever your hand finds to do, do it with all your might, for in the grave, where you are going, there is neither working nor planning nor knowledge nor wisdom.
- 11 I took another walk around the neighborhood and realized that on this earth as it is-- The race is not always to the swift, Nor the battle to the strong, Nor satisfaction to the wise, Nor riches to the smart, Nor grace to the learned. Sooner or later bad luck hits us all.
- 11 I have seen something else under the sun: The race is not to the swift or the battle to the strong, nor does food come to the wise or wealth to the brilliant or favor to the learned; but time and chance happen to them all.

- 12 No one can predict misfortune. Like fish caught in a cruel net or birds in a trap, So men and women are caught By accidents evil and sudden.
- 12 Moreover, no man knows when his hour will come: As fish are caught in a cruel net, or birds are taken in a snare, so men are trapped by evil times that fall unexpectedly upon them.
- 13 One day as I was observing how wisdom fares on this earth, I saw something that made me sit up and take notice.
- 13 I also saw under the sun this example of wisdom that greatly impressed me:
- 14 There was a small town with only a few people in it. A strong king came and mounted an attack, building trenches and attack posts around it.
- 14 There was once a small city with only a few people in it. And a powerful king came against it, surrounded it and built huge siegeworks against it.
- 15 There was a poor but wise man in that town whose wisdom saved the town, but he was promptly forgotten. (He was only a poor man, after all.)
- 15 Now there lived in that city a man poor but wise, and he saved the city by his wisdom. But nobody remembered that poor man.
- 16 All the same, I still say that wisdom is better than muscle, even though the wise poor man was treated with contempt and soon forgotten.
- 16 So I said, "Wisdom is better than strength." But the poor man's wisdom is despised, and his words are no longer heeded.
- 17 The quiet words of the wise are more effective Than the ranting of a king of fools.
- 17 The quiet words of the wise are more to be heeded than the shouts of a ruler of fools.
- 18 Wisdom is better than warheads, But one hothead can ruin the good earth.
- 18 Wisdom is better than weapons of war, but one sinner destroys much good.

Ecclesiastes 10

MSG

NIV

- 1 Dead flies in perfume make it stink, And a little foolishness decomposes much wisdom.
- 1 As dead flies give perfume a bad smell, so a little folly outweighs wisdom and honor.
- 2 Wise thinking leads to right living; Stupid thinking leads to wrong living.
- 2 The heart of the wise inclines to the right, but the heart of the fool to the left.
- 3 Fools on the road have no sense of direction. The way they walk tells the story: "There goes the fool again!"
- 3 Even as he walks along the road, the fool lacks sense and shows everyone how stupid he is.
- 4 If a ruler loses his temper against you, don't panic; A calm disposition quiets intemperate rage.
- 4 If a ruler's anger rises against you, do not leave your post; calmness can lay great errors to rest.
- 5 Here's a piece of bad business I've seen on this earth, An error that can be blamed on whoever is in charge:
- 5 There is an evil I have seen under the sun, the sort of error that arises from a ruler:
- 6 Immaturity is given a place of prominence, While maturity is made to take a back seat.
- 6 Fools are put in many high positions, while the rich occupy the low ones.
- 7 I've seen unproven upstarts riding in style, While experienced veterans are put out to pasture.
- 7 I have seen slaves on horseback, while princes go on foot like slaves.
- 8 Caution: The trap you set might catch you. Warning: Your accomplice in crime might double-cross you.
- 8 Whoever digs a pit may fall into it; whoever breaks through a wall may be bitten by a snake.
- 9 Safety first: Quarrying stones is dangerous. Be alert: Felling trees is hazardous.
- 9 Whoever quarries stones may be injured by them; whoever splits logs may be endangered by them.
- 10 Remember: The duller the ax the harder the work; Use your head: The more brains, the less muscle.

- 10 If the ax is dull and its edge unsharpened, more strength is needed but skill will bring success.
- 11 If the snake bites before it's been charmed, What's the point in then sending for the charmer?
- 11 If a snake bites before it is charmed, there is no profit for the charmer.
- 12 The words of a wise person are gracious. The talk of a fool self-destructs--
- 12 Words from a wise man's mouth are gracious, but a fool is consumed by his own lips.
- 13 He starts out talking nonsense And ends up spouting insanity and evil.
- 13 At the beginning his words are folly; at the end they are wicked madness--
- 14 Fools talk way too much, Chattering stuff they know nothing about.
- 14 and the fool multiplies words. No one knows what is coming-- who can tell him what will happen after him?
- 15 A decent day's work so fatigues fools That they can't find their way back to town.
- 15 A fool's work wearies him; he does not know the way to town.
- 16 Unlucky the land whose king is a young pup, And whose princes party all night.
- 16 Woe to you, O land whose king was a servant and whose princes feast in the morning.
- 17 Lucky the land whose king is mature, Where the princes behave themselves And don't drink themselves silly.
- 17 Blessed are you, O land whose king is of noble birth and whose princes eat at a proper time-- for strength and not for drunkenness.
- 18 A shiftless man lives in a tumbledown shack; A lazy woman ends up with a leaky roof.
- 18 If a man is lazy, the rafters sag; if his hands are idle, the house leaks.
- 19 Laughter and bread go together, And wine gives sparkle to life-- But it's money that makes the world go around.
- 19 A feast is made for laughter, and wine makes life merry, but money is the answer for everything.
- 20 Don't bad-mouth your leaders, not even under your breath, And don't abuse your betters, even in the privacy of your home. Loose talk has a

way of getting picked up and spread around. Little birds drop the crumbs of your gossip far and wide.

- 20 Do not revile the king even in your thoughts, or curse the rich in your bedroom, because a bird of the air may carry your words, and a bird on the wing may report what you say.

Ecclesiastes 11

MSG

NIV

- 1 Be generous: Invest in acts of charity. Charity yields high returns.
- 1 Cast your bread upon the waters, for after many days you will find it again.
- 2 Don't hoard your goods; spread them around. Be a blessing to others. This could be your last night.
- 2 Give portions to seven, yes to eight, for you do not know what disaster may come upon the land.
- 3 When the clouds are full of water, it rains. When the wind blows down a tree, it lies where it falls.
- 3 If clouds are full of water, they pour rain upon the earth. Whether a tree falls to the south or to the north, in the place where it falls, there will it lie.
- 4 Don't sit there watching the wind. Do your own work. Don't stare at the clouds. Get on with your life.
- 4 Whoever watches the wind will not plant; whoever looks at the clouds will not reap.
- 5 Just as you'll never understand the mystery of life forming in a pregnant woman, So you'll never understand the mystery at work in all that God does.
- 5 As you do not know the path of the wind, or how the body is formed in a mother's womb, so you cannot understand the work of God, the Maker of all things.
- 6 Go to work in the morning and stick to it until evening without watching the clock. You never know from moment to moment how your work will turn out in the end.

- 6 Sow your seed in the morning, and at evening let not your hands be idle, for you do not know which will succeed, whether this or that, or whether both will do equally well.
- 7 Oh, how sweet the light of day, And how wonderful to live in the sunshine!
- 7 Light is sweet, and it pleases the eyes to see the sun.
- 8 Even if you live a long time, don't take a single day for granted. Take delight in each light-filled hour, Remembering that there will also be many dark days And that most of what comes your way is smoke.
- 8 However many years a man may live, let him enjoy them all. But let him remember the days of darkness, for they will be many. Everything to come is meaningless.
- 9 You who are young, make the most of your youth. Relish your youthful vigor. Follow the impulses of your heart. If something looks good to you, pursue it. But know also that not just anything goes; You have to answer to God for every last bit of it.
- 9 Be happy, young man, while you are young, and let your heart give you joy in the days of your youth. Follow the ways of your heart and whatever your eyes see, but know that for all these things God will bring you to judgment.
- 10 Live footloose and fancy free-- You won't be young forever. Youth lasts about as long as smoke.
- 10 So then, banish anxiety from your heart and cast off the troubles of your body, for youth and vigor are meaningless.

Ecclesiastes 12

MSG

NIV

- 1 Honor and enjoy your Creator while you're still young, Before the years take their toll and your vigor wanes,
- 1 Remember your Creator in the days of your youth, before the days of trouble come and the years approach when you will say, "I find no pleasure in them"--
- 2 Before your vision dims and the world blurs And the winter years keep you close to the fire.

- 2 before the sun and the light and the moon and the stars grow dark, and
the clouds return after the rain;
- 3 In old age, your body no longer serves you so well. Muscles slacken, grip
weakens, joints stiffen. The shades are pulled down on the world.
- 3 when the keepers of the house tremble, and the strong men stoop, when
the grinders cease because they are few, and those looking through the
windows grow dim;
- 4 You can't come and go at will. Things grind to a halt. The hum of the
household fades away. You are wakened now by bird-song.
- 4 when the doors to the street are closed and the sound of grinding fades;
when men rise up at the sound of birds, but all their songs grow faint;
- 5 Hikes to the mountains are a thing of the past. Even a stroll down the
road has its terrors. Your hair turns apple-blossom white, Adorning a
fragile and impotent matchstick body. Yes, you're well on your way to
eternal rest, While your friends make plans for your funeral.
- 5 when men are afraid of heights and of dangers in the streets; when the
almond tree blossoms and the grasshopper drags himself along and
desire no longer is stirred. Then man goes to his eternal home and
mourners go about the streets.
- 6 Life, lovely while it lasts, is soon over. Life as we know it, precious and
beautiful, ends.
- 6 Remember him--before the silver cord is severed, or the golden bowl is
broken; before the pitcher is shattered at the spring, or the wheel broken
at the well,
- 7 The body is put back in the same ground it came from. The spirit returns
to God, who first breathed it.
- 7 and the dust returns to the ground it came from, and the spirit returns to
God who gave it.
- 8 It's all smoke, nothing but smoke. The Quester says that everything's
smoke.
- 8 Meaningless! Meaningless! says the Teacher. "Everything is
meaningless!"
- 9 Besides being wise himself, the Quester also taught others knowledge.
He weighed, examined, and arranged many proverbs.
- 9 Not only was the Teacher wise, but also he imparted knowledge to the
people. He pondered and searched out and set in order many proverbs.

- 10 The Quester did his best to find the right words and write the plain truth.
- 10 The Teacher searched to find just the right words, and what he wrote was upright and true.
- 11 The words of the wise prod us to live well. They're like nails hammered home, holding life together. They are given by God, the one Shepherd.
- 11 The words of the wise are like goads, their collected sayings like firmly embedded nails--given by one Shepherd.
- 12 But regarding anything beyond this, dear friend, go easy. There's no end to the publishing of books, and constant study wears you out so you're no good for anything else.
- 12 Be warned, my son, of anything in addition to them. Of making many books there is no end, and much study wearies the body.
- 13 The last and final word is this: Fear God. Do what he tells you.
- 13 Now all has been heard; here is the conclusion of the matter: Fear God and keep his commandments, for this is the whole duty of man.
- 14 And that's it. Eventually God will bring everything that we do out into the open and judge it according to its hidden intent, whether it's good or evil.
- 14 For God will bring every deed into judgment, including every hidden thing, whether it is good or evil.